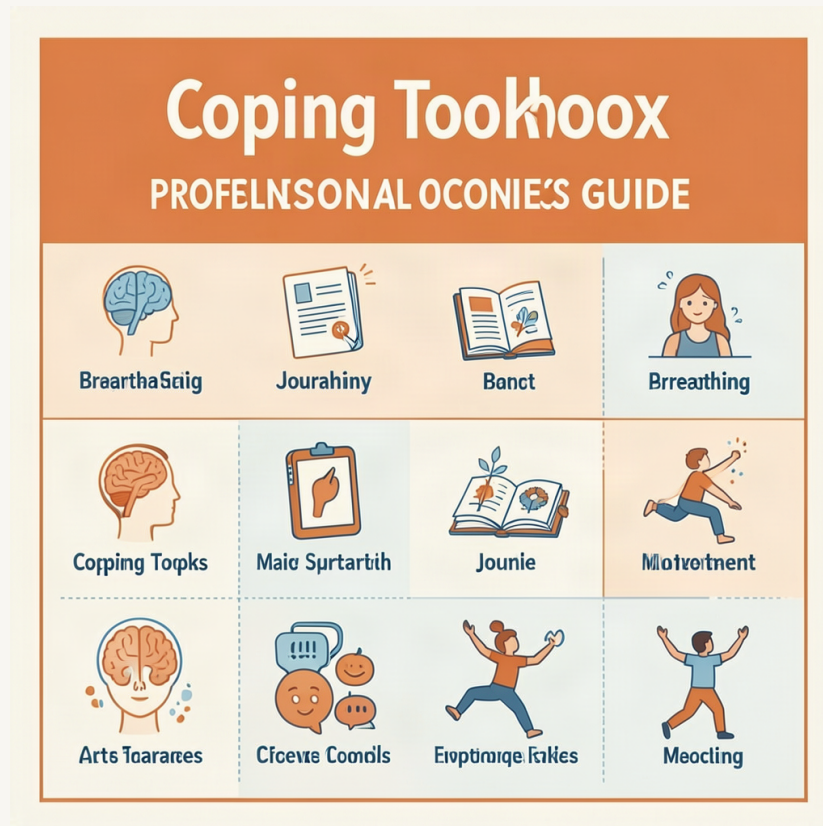




Coping Toolbox

Build a personal menu of practical supports before you need them

Prepare several safe, realistic coping options so you are not forced to invent a plan in a hard moment.

Coping Toolbox

Teens and adults; adaptable for families and classrooms

A toolbox gives you choices

Different moments need different supports. A useful toolbox contains brief actions for mild stress, longer supports for harder days, and people to contact when you should not manage alone.

How to use this tool

Work through the pages in any order. Use a pen, pencil, or digital annotation tool. Keep what helps; leave what does not.

Important

This is a self-management planning aid, not treatment. Avoid tools that are painful, risky, intoxicating, or used to harm yourself or others.

Toolbox brainstorm

Body

stretch, rest, water, a short walk

Senses

music, texture, fresh air, a cool drink

Thoughts

write it down, a balanced sentence, a reminder card

Connection

support text, sit near someone, ask for help

Environment

lower noise, change rooms, clear one surface

Practical action

one small task, a timer, a next appointment

My three-level plan

Mild stress

Choose two tools that take under two minutes.

Medium stress

Choose two tools that take five to fifteen minutes.

High stress

Choose a safer location, a support person, and a professional or crisis resource if needed. If you may hurt yourself or someone else, cannot stay safe, or there is immediate danger, contact emergency services or an appropriate crisis resource now.

My support script

Use this when you want support without needing someone to solve everything.

I am having a hard moment. I do not need you to fix it; could you...

The most helpful kind of support is...

If I do not reply, please...

Tool experiment review

Situation

Tool I used

Effort level (0-10)

Result

Keep, change, or retire this tool?

Sources and use note

This printable tool was designed with general self-care and coping concepts from the sources below. It is educational material, not health care or therapy.

National Institute of Mental Health: Caring for Your Mental Health

Self-care, connection, stress-management framing

<https://www.nimh.nih.gov/health/topics/caring-for-your-mental-health>

National Institute of Mental Health: So Stressed Out

Journaling, relaxation, mindfulness, sleep, and support concepts

<https://www.nimh.nih.gov/health/publications/so-stressed-out-fact-sheet>

NHS: Breathing exercises for stress

Comfortable, unforced breathing guidance

<https://www.nhs.uk/mental-health/self-help/guides-tools-and-activities/breathing-exercises-for-stress/>

WebMD: What Is Box Breathing?

Optional paced-breathing presentation

<https://www.webmd.com/balance/what-is-box-breathing>

WebMD: Quick Stress-Relief Rituals

Sensory grounding context

<https://www.webmd.com/depression/quick-stress-relief-rituals>

American Psychological Association: Stress management tips

Thought, emotion, behavior, and reframing context

<https://www.apa.org/topics/stress/tips>

CASEL: Fundamentals of SEL

Emotion identification and self-management framing

<https://casel.org/fundamentals-of-sel/>

CDC: Information for Family Caregivers

Caregiver capacity, breaks, and support framing

<https://www.cdc.gov/disability-and-health/about/information-for-family-caregivers.html>

Child Mind Institute: How to Help Children Calm Down

Coping-ahead and child-friendly calming support

<https://childmind.org/article/how-to-help-children-calm-down/>

Wikipedia: Mindfulness

Plain-language background only; not clinical authority

<https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Mindfulness>

Reddit community discussions

User-centered presentation inspiration only; not clinical authority

https://www.reddit.com/r/Anxiety/comments/1ch67c8/making_an_anxiety_tool_box_what_should_i_put_in_it/

YouTube guided box-breathing example

Visual pacing inspiration only; not clinical authority

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=tEmt1Znux58>